Political Tolerance of Protest among Citizens and Representatives in Five Democracies

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Abstract

Political tolerance of others' civil liberties is a cornerstone of liberal democracy, yet what drives its erosion remains contested. Does intolerance reflect opposition to group members' behavior or ideology? And do elected representatives, who make decisions about civil liberties, weigh these factors differently than citizens? We examine these questions with a conjoint experiment among more than 1,000 representatives and nearly 5,000 citizens across Belgium, Denmark, Germany, Portugal, and Switzerland. We show that representatives are more tolerant than citizens, but rely on the same criteria. Among both citizens and representatives, group members' behavior, particularly violent confrontations, is the strongest driver of opposition to their protests. Yet representatives and citizens also selectively extend the right to protest along ideological lines, penalizing ideological out-groups. These findings suggest that political tolerance is grounded in reciprocity for democratic norms, but remains conditional: even elected representatives are less willing to extend civil liberties to ideological opponents.

1 Introduction

Political tolerance of others' civil liberties is fundamental to democratic politics. Scholars argue that political intolerance contributes to the erosion of civil liberties (Sullivan and Hendriks 2009), social trust (Sullivan and Transue 1999; Morgan and Kelly 2021), and political violence (Jahnke et al. 2022; Piazza 2024). Previous studies have demonstrated that citizens can support restrictions on the political participation of certain groups[1] (Freitag and Rapp 2013; Crawford and Pilanski 2014; Adman and Strömblad 2018), but the origins of this support are still being debated. Is intolerance principally a reaction to observable behaviours exhibited by groups? Or do people reject a group simply because of who it is or whom it represents, irrespective of behaviour?

Classical studies attribute the source of political intolerance to individual-level predispositions, such as personality traits, core values, and political ideology (Zellman and Sears 1971; Sniderman 1975). For example, Sullivan et al. (1981) find that social and demographic factors have no direct and little indirect effect on political tolerance, which reflects instead perceived threat and commitment to general democratic norms. That commitment, they argue, is partly the result of an ideological calculation weighing tolerance against other political values and partly a matter of individuals' psychological openness and security. More recent studies have reintroduced group dynamics into the study of political intolerance (Persson and Widmalm 2025; Bos et al. 2023). Specifically, Gibson et al. (2020) suggest that investigating group-level variance in political intolerance would shed light on the kinds of groups most likely to be targeted. However, focusing on which groups are targeted leaves open the question of whether intolerance is based on who the groups are or what they do.

The literature suggests two distinct sources of intolerance: group behavior and individual dispositions. Firstly, individuals may support restrictions in response to the actions of a group.

[1] In this paper, we define groups as advocacy organizations whose members engage in various political activities (e.g., street protests, public debates, campaigning) to influence public opinion and the policymaking process, see Andrews and Edwards (2004)).

This logic of behavior has two distinct mechanism. On the one hand, groups that violate the law or resort to violence can be viewed as violating the norms of democratic coexistence. As a result, they forfeit their right to democratic protection, which is consistent with a "democratic self-defence" rationale (Malkopoulou and Norman 2018). On the other hand, groups may be restricted because their activities pose a tangible personal threat. When a protest is large or nearby, the potential for disruption increases, regardless of whether any rules have been broken. Secondly, intolerance may reflect identity- and ideology-based exclusion, whereby some groups are deemed illegitimate participants regardless of their behaviour (Gibson and Gouws 2000; Halperin et al. 2009). In this paper, we argue that it matters to distinguish these two distinct sources since they imply different empirical evidence. If behavior drives intolerance, then restrictions should strongly respond to groups' actions and the threat they pose, with modest differences across group identities. However, if identity drives intolerance, restrictions should focus on group identity, with behavior mattering far less.

While prior research has made great efforts to identify factors related to political intolerance across different institutional contexts (Duch and Gibson 1992; Mondak and Sanders 2003; Kirchner et al. 2011; Stoeckel and Ceka 2023), existing studies have two limitations. Firstly, we lack causal estimates of the relative importance of competing cues, as it is rarely possible to estimate the effects of individual cues by target group within the same design. While intolerance is known to vary with a group's ideological direction (Crawford 2014; Gibson et al. 2020), the question of whether behavioral cues are weighed differently depending on which group displays them has received far less attention. Secondly, and more importantly, most studies examine the public rather than politicians.[2] This omission matters because the binding decisions that determine whether restrictions are imposed are made by representatives, not citizens. Therefore, their tolerance shapes democratic practice more directly than public opinion does. According to elitist theories of democracy, representatives should meet this responsibility by being more

[2]For an exception see Shamir (1991).

tolerant than the public and acting as a bulwark against majoritarian intolerance (Gibson and Duch 1991). However, this expectation is contested Sullivan et al. (1993, 128) caution that elite tolerance may not constrain repression when public opinion itself is intolerant, since representatives can translate majoritarian pressure into restrictive policy. Whether elites in fact live up to the elitist expectation is thus an open empirical question—and one that comparative evidence is currently too scarce to answer.

Our study aims to address three questions. First, do elected representatives consider these issues differently than citizens do? Second, do judgments about protest rights respond more to what a group does, such as breaking democratic rules or posing a personal threat, or to who the group is? Third, when identity matters, does it operate through the ideological distance between the judges and the groups they evaluate? To adjudicate these competing explanations of political intolerance, we conducted a conjoint experiment with $\approx$ 5,000 citizens and $\approx$ 1,000 elected politicians from five European democracies: Belgium, Denmark, Germany, Portugal, and Switzerland. Respondents evaluated how strongly a political group should be prohibited from holding a street protest. Each protest scenario varied in five attributes, which were drawn from existing theories, including the group's ideological orientation, engagement in illegal activities, a history of violent confrontation, protest size, and physical proximity to the respondents. By randomizing these attributes independently, we can isolate three potential sources of intolerance: who the group is, whether its conduct violates democratic rules, and the personal threat posed by its protest. Then, we can examine how these sources interact. Real groups differ in who they are and how they behave at once, so observational data cannot achieve this separation.

We find that political intolerance is primarily shaped by group behavioral, though not exclusively. Amongst citizens and politicians alike, violent confrontations constitute the strongest predictor of support for restricting protest rights, followed by illegal conduct. This penalty reflects the violation of democratic norms rather than the physical threat that protests pose. Illegal but

peaceful protests are penalized nearly as heavily. Protest size has no effect, and the penalty for violence does not increase when protests are larger or nearer to respondents. However, behavior is not the whole story. Respondents apply tolerance selectively across ideological lines, systematically penalizing groups located on the opposing side of the political spectrum. Among citizens, though, this directional pattern collapses into broad intolerance of protest at the far right. Politicians are substantially more tolerant than citizens overall, yet they rely on remarkably similar evaluative criteria when deciding whether political rights should be curtailed.

This study makes two main contributions. First, it clarifies a longstanding debate about the foundations of political intolerance. We show that judgments about political rights are driven primarily by assessments of group behavior, especially violations of democratic norms, rather than by who the groups are. At the same time, both citizens and politicians remain less tolerant of ideological opponents. Among citizens, however, this directional bias gives way to broad intolerance of protest, regardless of the group, at the far right. In other words, procedural commitments coexist with ideological ones. Second, the study provides the first systematic cross-national evidence on how elected representatives evaluate the political rights of groups. Existing research has focused overwhelmingly on citizens, despite the fact that representatives are often responsible for making consequential decisions about protest and political expression. We find that politicians are substantially more tolerant than citizens overall. Yet they also exhibit ideological selectivity, extending fewer rights to groups whose political views are distant from their own. Interestingly, even though the politicians are more tolerant overall, they still apply protest rights unevenly across political groups. Greater tolerance does not necessarily translate into even-handedness across the ideological divide. Overall, our findings suggest that democratic reciprocity remains a powerful foundation of political tolerance. Yet, support for political rights is not unconditional. Even among elected representatives, the willingness to protect political expression depends in part on who seeks to exercise those rights.

2 Theory and Hypotheses

In his study of American democracy, Alexis de Tocqueville identified three primary factors that he considered essential to the survival of the democratic republic (Sullivan and Transue 1999). Along with context and law, he argued that the manners and customs commonly observed among Americans constituted an important pillar of democracy. From this perspective, Griffith et al. (1956) concluded that there should be agreement on the procedural standards for negotiating substantive issues, as well as on core values such as freedom, equality, and individualism. This is all the more important because democratic institutions depend heavily on political culture, which implies that citizens must have a certain perspective on political life (Almond and Verba 1963; Dahl 2008; Huntington 1984). According to Gibson (1992a), political tolerance is particularly necessary of this required orientation.

Political tolerance typically refers to an individual's propensity to support political freedoms for groups whose members hold values or lifestyles that are disliked by the same individual (Sullivan et al. 1993; Adman and Strömblad 2018). In doing so, the study of political tolerance has a long tradition (Stoeckel and Ceka 2023). One of the first studies, conducted by Stouffer (1955), examined both American citizens' and community leaders' support for the civil liberties of socialists, atheists, communists, and fellow travellers. The study found that citizens were willing to take away the civil rights of some groups, especially leftists, because they were perceived as a threat. In contrast, representatives were more supportive of the rights of the groups studied than were citizens. In the following years, Sullivan et al. (1993) proposed measuring tolerance by (1) identifying individual perceptions of other groups and (2) determining the extent to which individuals support or oppose the civil rights of these groups. Most recent studies have followed this logic and investigated the relationship between political tolerance and political ideology (Crawford 2014; Crawford and Pilanski 2014), emotions (Claassen 2016; Sirin et al. 2016; Gibson et al. 2020), and affective polarization (Berntzen et al. 2024; Tilley et al. 2026).

Early research on political tolerance relied largely on single-country studies in advanced industrial democracies (Sullivan et al. 1979; Sullivan et al. 1981; Sniderman et al. 2004). Later scholarship extended this agenda to then-new democracies (Karpov 1999; Kaplan 2024; Gibson 1992a; Gibson and Duch 1993; Chong et al. 2024). More recent work has adopted an explicitly comparative approach, examining tolerance across Western Europe (Weldon 2006), across Western and Eastern Europe (Marquart-Pyatt and Paxton 2007; Stoeckel and Ceka 2023), and across established and newer democracies worldwide (Peffley and Rohrschneider 2003). In the last couple of years, studies have focused on experimental research, often examining the underlying norms of political tolerance (Bjånesøy et al. 2023; Neuner and Ramirez 2023; Vanagt et al. 2025; Valentim et al. 2025). In general, Stoeckel and Ceka (2023) identifies two[3] broad categories of determinants of political intolerance: (1) Attitudinal and (2) political determinants.

A central attitudinal theory suggests that political intolerance is linked to perceptions of threat. Disliked groups may be perceived as endangering the values, social standing or legal and political order of the in-group (Gibson and Gouws 2003; Huddy et al. 2005). Such threat perceptions often outweigh abstract commitments to civil liberties and democratic principles when they are salient, making citizens more willing to endorse restrictions (Stouffer 1955; McClosky and Brill 1983; Sullivan 1985). Importantly, the perceived threat is not uniform across targets, since some groups are judged as more dangerous to liberal democracy than others. Petersen et al. (2011) argue that intolerance is especially acute when groups are perceived to violate democratic norms, but reciprocity considerations can preserve tolerance towards disliked groups that adhere to these norms. Beyond threat tied to particular targets, broader democratic orientations also matter, such as stronger support for democracy (Marquart-Pyatt and Paxton 2007), commitment to democratic norms (Peffley and Rohrschneider 2003), and satisfaction with how democracy works (Weldon

[3] A third set of factors concerns sociodemographics factors. From this perspective, tolerance is largely learned rather than innate. Education is the most consistent predictor, often attributed to greater exposure to diverse ideas and people, as well as socialization into democratic norms. Levels of tolerance are also shaped by the length of democratic experience, and cohort differences are observed in post-communist contexts (Marquart-Pyatt and Paxton 2007). In contrast, the evidence for other correlates, such as age, gender, class, urban-rural residence, and religiosity, is more mixed and varies across countries and over time.

2006). Furthermore, Stoeckel and Ceka (2023) showed that individuals high in conspiratorial thinking and low in cosmopolitanism being significantly less tolerant.

Another line of research considers political tolerance in relation to how citizens engage with politics, their sense of efficacy, and their ideology. Participation in democratic life can cultivate tolerance by providing experience of pluralism and civil liberties. For example, "democratic activism" (e.g., petitions, boycotts and participation in movements) is positively associated with tolerance (Peffley and Rohrschneider 2003). Similarly, political efficacy is linked to greater tolerance, whereas feelings of powerlessness can make the political influence of disliked groups seem especially threatening (Duch and Gibson 1992). Since left- and right-leaning citizens tend to view different opponents as illegitimate, scholars emphasise the importance of content-controlled measures that allow the target group to vary (Sullivan et al. 1993; Marcus 1995; Crawford 2014). However, the evidence is mixed when targets are fixed: Lindner and Nosek (2009) report higher intolerance among right-leaning Americans when using fixed groups, while content-controlled approaches reveal that intolerance is often directed at ideological outgroups (Crawford 2014). Ultimately, intolerance tends to be strongest among ideological extremists rather than moderates (Van Prooijen and Krouwel 2019). While political interest can foster tolerance in certain contexts, e.g., the United States and Western Europe, it can have the opposite effect in others, e.g. Eastern Europe (Marquart-Pyatt and Paxton 2007).

In the following, we argue that intolerance, understood as the willingness to restrict the civil liberties of disliked groups, reflects both what a group does (e.g., violating democratic rules or posing a threat) and who the group is. Moreover, we suggest that these considerations operate among citizens and political representatives alike. We focus on representatives for three reasons. First, they have disproportionate influence: they draft, enact, and enforce the laws that determine the boundaries of civil liberties (Curry 2015). Thus, their willingness to restrict disliked groups has a far greater impact on democratic practice than that of any individual citizen. Second, there is

a long tradition of treating elites as carriers of the democratic creed (McClosky 1964; Stouffer 1955; Prothro and Grigg 1960). They are considered more exposed to political pluralism and more practiced in compromise (Gutmann and Thompson 2010; Lijphart 1977), which is why they are expected to have firmer attitudes towards civil liberties. Third, despite their centrality, empirical evidence remains overwhelmingly at the mass level. Paired elite-citizen data on tolerance are scarce, leaving the elitist expectation largely untested against contemporary alternatives (Sullivan et al. 1982). Building on this literature, we expect that, on average, representatives will be more tolerant than citizens. Their sustained exposure to political pluralism and democratic procedures should increase their commitment to civil liberties (Gibson and Duch 1991; McClosky 1964). We remain agnostic about the mechanism. A higher elite baseline may reflect either socialization into democratic norms through political experience or the selection of more tolerant and educated individuals into political roles. We therefore formulate the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1. *Politicians are less supportive of restricting groups' civil liberties compared to citizens.*

Prior research argues that intolerance is partly a defensive reaction to perceived threats to physical safety, material interests, or public order (Huddy et al. 2005; Bredemeier and Berenbaum 2008). According to this theory, individuals should exhibit more restrictive preferences when the group's activities are perceived as an immediate and concrete threat rather than an abstract or distant one. Proximity and size indicate self-interested threat rather than principled objection. They increase the personal cost of a protest regardless of whether the group has broken any rules. Spatial proximity is one way this immediacy operates. When contentious collective action occurs nearby, potential costs become more apparent, such as disruption to daily routines, risk of escalation, and loss of control over one's environment (Balžekienė et al. 2025; Schlueter and Scheepers 2010). Distance acts as a buffer, i.e., a disliked group is easier to tolerate from a distance than on one's doorstep. Group size operates through a related logic of disruptive capacity. Larger mobilizations can block

streets, strain police resources, and increase the likelihood of confrontation, making them seem more costly to nearby residents (McPhail and McCarthy 2005; Hellmann et al. 2021). However, we recognize that size may also cut the other way. Large turnouts can signal mainstream support and social legitimacy, which could temper restrictive impulses (McAllister and Studlar 1991). But, in the context of protest, where disruption and public order are the salient considerations, we expect the disruptive-capacity mechanism to dominate. Both proximity and size should have a similar effect on citizens and politicians since personal exposure to disruption increases the perceived risk, regardless of institutional role. We, thus, formulate the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 2. *Politicians and citizens are more supportive of restricting groups' civil liberties when the groups' activities constitute a direct local threat compared to a more distant one.*

Hypothesis 3. *Politicians and citizens are more supportive of restricting groups' civil liberties when the groups are larger.*

Previous studies distinguish between restricting the rights of a group because they are disliked and restricting their rights because they are perceived as violating the rules of democratic coexistence (Petersen et al. 2011; Trüdinger and Ziller 2023). In general, groups associated with violent or non-democratic behavior are consistently less tolerated (Kuklinski et al. 1991; Sullivan et al. 1993). However, the reason matters. Petersen et al. (2011) argue that tolerance judgments follow a logic of reciprocity. Civil liberties are extended to disliked groups on the condition that they respect democratic rules, and groups that break those rules forfeit that protection. This means that individual judgments take into account a group's behaviour rather than its values. Thus, reciprocity can sustain tolerance toward a disliked but lawful group that pure hostility would not. The defining property of a reciprocity-based standard, as opposed to an hostility-based one, is universalism (Benhabib 2007). Since the trigger is behavior rather than identity, we expect the standard to be applied symmetrically, restricting rule-breakers to a similar degree, regardless of their group affiliation. This logic should apply to both citizens and politicians. Illegal action

signals that a group has violated the reciprocal bargain, which can override abstract commitments to civil liberties. After all, politicians have institutional responsibilities for public order and legal compliance, i.e., illegal action increases the perceived administrative, policing, and reputational costs of allowing a group to mobilize (Wenzelburger 2015). Therefore, we formulate the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 4. *Politicians and citizens are more supportive of restricting groups' civil liberties if the groups have engaged in illegal activities than if they have not.*

In comparison to the prior argument on the relationship between illegal activities and political tolerance, violence involves both the logic of reciprocity and a distinct mechanism of physical threat. Similar to illegality, a violent track record indicates that a group has violated the fundamental rule of democratic coexistence: that political conflict be waged peacefully. Consequently, the group may forfeit reciprocal protection. However, violence goes beyond unlawful yet peaceful action. It directly threatens bystanders and increases the perceived likelihood that a given mobilization will escalate (Linklater 2011; Hutchison 2014; Conteh-Morgan 2004). Even when a group's current action is framed as a protest, a violent behavior makes preventive restrictions seem prudent rather than punitive. Therefore, violence differs from illegal but peaceful conduct not in terms of whether it breaches democratic norms, but in terms of the additional physical threat it carries. This distinction is important in theory as it separates intolerance driven by norm violation from intolerance driven by the danger posed by a group. These two mechanisms tend to be bundled together in ordinary observational settings. This dual mechanism should operate among citizens and representatives alike. For both groups, violence compounds a reciprocity violation with a safety threat. While politicians may be more accountable for public order, we expect violence to lead to restrictions through the same two channels rather than different ones. We therefore formulate the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 5. *Politicians and citizens are more supportive of restricting groups' civil liberties if*

the groups have a history of violent confrontations than if they do not.

The above hypotheses on the reprocity logic describe a universalistic standard, whereby restrictions are triggered by a group's behavior and are applied regardless of the group's political orientation. However, a central insight of the political tolerance literature is that intolerance is also particularistic, directed at specific groups rather than applied evenly (Gibson 1992b). Citizens and representatives are not uniformly tolerant or intolerant—rather, they may selectively restrict groups they perceive as ideologically threatening (Crawford and Pilanski 2014). Ideological labels signal whether a group belongs to the respondent's political in-group or out-group. Since ideological out-groups are associated with different values, policy goals, and social identities, they are more likely to be regarded as illegitimate participants in the political process (Greene 1999). This perception is reinforced by motivated reasoning, whereby respondents interpret the actions and intentions of ideological opponents more negatively, attributing greater danger or bad faith to them (Fischer et al. 2016). Among citizens, ideological group conflict is closely tied to identity and emotion, making restrictions against opponents seem morally justified or politically necessary (Suhay 2015). Among politicians, ideological opponents are strategic competitors. Limiting their mobilization appears to reduce agenda-setting power, dampen pressure from street politics, and protect one's own coalition from reputational or electoral risks (Layman et al. 2006). Beyond these instrumental considerations, partisan hostility also has an emotional basis: out-group hostility functions as a social identity and does not require justification based on a group's behaviour or policy positions (Iyengar et al. 2019; Mason 2018). As affect attaches to the identity of a group rather than its behavior, some directional intolerance should persist even absent a behavioural provocation. In both cases, then, intolerance is expected to be directional: left-leaning respondents should target right-leaning groups, and right-leaning respondents should target left-leaning groups. Therefore, we formulate the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 6. *Left-leaning politicians and citizens are more supportive of restricting the civil liberties of right-leaning groups than those of left-leaning and neutral groups.*

Hypothesis 7. *Right-leaning politicians and citizens are more supportive of restricting the civil liberties of left-leaning groups than those of right-leaning and neutral groups.*

This directional expectation raises a further question about the partisan gap itself: Does it differ by role? Given their firmer commitment to civil liberties, it is tempting to expect that representatives are more even-handed than citizens and less swayed by a target's ideological direction. However, the backsliding logic (Graham and Svolik 2020; Svolik et al. 2023) provides no reason to expect the partisan slope to differ by role. If partisan trade-offs affect the politically sophisticated, then representatives should exhibit the same directional pull as citizens, differing only in their baselines.[4]

Data and Methods

We conducted an original survey among a nationally representative sample of 4,965 citizens and 1,091 elected representatives in Belgium, Denmark, Germany, Portugal, and Switzerland. The data collection took place between 2025 and 2026. The elite survey was administered through in-person and online interviews with elected representatives in the national parliaments of Belgium, Denmark, Germany, Portugal, and Switzerland, the Parliament of Wallonia, and the Swiss cantonal parliaments of Bern and Fribourg.[5] Representatives from the remaining Swiss cantonal parliaments completed the survey online. The citizen survey was also administered online.[6]

[4] As this comparison was not preregistered, it is treated as exploratory. A second exploratory question is whether this directional gap persists when groups are lawful and non-violent. If reciprocity fully neutralised partisan bias, the ideological direction of a group should cease to matter once its behaviour is beyond reproach. A gap that survives at this clean-behaviour baseline would instead suggest that reciprocity restricts directional intolerance without eliminating it entirely. Similarly, we did not preregister this comparison and treat it as suggestive.

[5] During the in-person interviews, respondents completed the survey directly on a tablet provided by the research team. This procedure preserved the anonymity of responses while ensuring that the questionnaire was completed by the representative rather than delegated to a staff member or assistant.

[6] Further details on the fieldwork, including the representativeness of the politicians' data, are reported in the Online Appendix.

The survey included a conjoint experiment designed to identify the factors that shape support for restricting protest. The conjoint design is particularly suited for our research question. First, by independently varying the characteristics of the protesting group and the nature of protest, the design enables us to identify whether intolerance is driven primarily by who protesters are or by what they do. Second, because respondents evaluate multidimensional profiles, conjoint tasks reduce the salience of socially sensitive characteristics and may therefore attenuate social desirability pressures (Horiuchi et al. 2022). This feature is particularly important in the context of protest restrictions by representatives. Finally, the repeated evaluation of multiple profiles provides within-respondent variation that allows us to examine whether the determinants of intolerance vary across social and political groups.

Design and Measurement

The conjoint task consisted of respondents being asked to consider a series of hypothetical scenarios in which a group was planning a street protest in their country. Each respondent was shown four pairs of profiles. Our outcome of interest is the support for banning each of the shown groups from holding a street protest. Responses were recorded on an 11-point scale ranging from 0 ("Totally disagree with the ban") to 10 ("Totally agree with the ban").

We used a rating-based conjoint, rather than a forced-choice design, to avoid imposing artificial trade-offs and reduce the ethical considerations associated with directly comparing potentially sensitive groups (Miller and Ziegler 2024; Treger 2025). The rating outcome also provides more fine-grained information on the intensity of support for restricting protest rights than a binary choice would and helps identify respondents who categorically accept or reject all profiles (Bansak et al. 2021), which is particularly relevant for studying political tolerance.

The paired design is motivated by efficiency and response quality. Elected representatives are a scarce and time-constrained population, and pairing halves the number of tasks. The paired

design has also been associated with greater respondent engagement and less satisficing (Hainmueller et al. 2015). The cost of this design choice is that a profile's rating might be shifted by the attributes of the profile shown alongside it. We find no evidence of such effects: the paired profile's attributes are jointly unrelated to a profile's rating ($F = 1.32$, $p = .25$), the effect of an attribute does not depend on the paired profile's corresponding attribute ($F = 0.67$, $p = .64$), and AMCEs do not differ by profile position ($F = 1.04$, $p = .40$). The standard conjoint diagnostics likewise give no indication of fatigue or learning across tasks ($F = 1.09$, $p = .36$) (Hainmueller et al. 2014).

Conjoint Attributes

Each conjoint profile contains five attributes: group type, whether the group had engaged in illegal activities, whether its actions involved violent confrontations, the protests' location, and the size of the protest group. Attribute levels are independently randomized for each profile, with the exception of group type, which is constrained to avoid repetition within profile pairs. The design directly map onto theoretical framework and allows us to assess the competing theoretical claims about the foundations of intolerance.

The group type includes climate activists, pro-life groups, and farmers. This selection stems from two main theoretical and empirical motivations. First, it avoids groups with inextricable links to confounding attributes. Presenting groups widely associated with violence, such as far-right organizations, in a non-violent context would threaten the external validity and credibility of the experimental design (Hainmueller et al. 2014). Second, the three groups span the left–right divide and vary in how negatively they are evaluated.[7] In our data, pro-life groups are the most frequently indicated as the respondent's least-liked group of the three, by 20.1% of citizens and

[7] A battery of survey questions on political tolerance was administered alongside the conjoint experiment. In this battery, respondents rated seven groups (far-right groups, far-left groups, anti-vaccination groups, climate groups, pro-life groups, LGBTQ+ groups, and farmers) on a 0–10 like–dislike scale. A respondent's least-liked group is the one receiving their lowest rating.

22.4% of representatives, followed by climate activists (8.6% and 5.4%) and farmers (3.7% and 0.8%) This variation allows us to better test whether and how respondents' evaluations of protest depend on who is protesting.

The remaining attributes serve two main purposes. First, they allow us to distinguish responses to the group from responses to its behavior. Previous research shows that political tolerance declines when groups engage in violence or violate democratic rules (Petersen et al. 2011). Yet the extent to which particular groups are perceived as violent or undemocratic varies across individuals and contexts. We therefore present groups that can plausibly engage in more or less violent or illegal activities and experimentally vary their behavior to isolate the independent effect of these behavioral cues.

Second, these attributes permit to adjudicate between competing explanations for why violent and undemocratic behavior reduces political tolerance. Existing research attributes this relationship either to perceptions of threat (Edwards and Arnon 2021) or to reciprocity norms, whereby groups that violate democratic principles are viewed as less deserving of democratic protections (Petersen et al. 2011). To distinguish between these mechanisms, we experimentally vary the location and size of the protest, thereby manipulating the level of threat respondents are likely to perceive. Furthermore, interacting these attributes with illegal and violent behavior allows us to assess whether opposition to protesters primarily reflects reciprocity-based objections or concerns about personal risk. Together, this design provides a more precise assessment of the behavioral foundations of political intolerance than has been possible in previous research.

Analyses and Results

We begin our analysis by examining the effect of group attributes on support for banning street protests among politicians and citizens.[8] We estimate a linear regression model that interacts each conjoint attribute with representative dummy (citizen versus elected representative) and allows the difference between citizens and representatives to vary across countries through country-respondent interactions:

$$Ban_{ict} = \beta_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{J} \beta_j Trait_{jict} + \alpha Rep_i + \sum_{j=1}^{J} \delta_j (Trait_{jict} \times Rep_i) + \sum_{c=1}^{C-1} \gamma_c Country_{ic} + \sum_{c=1}^{C-1} \lambda_c (Country_{ic} \times Rep_i) + \epsilon_{ict} \quad (1)$$

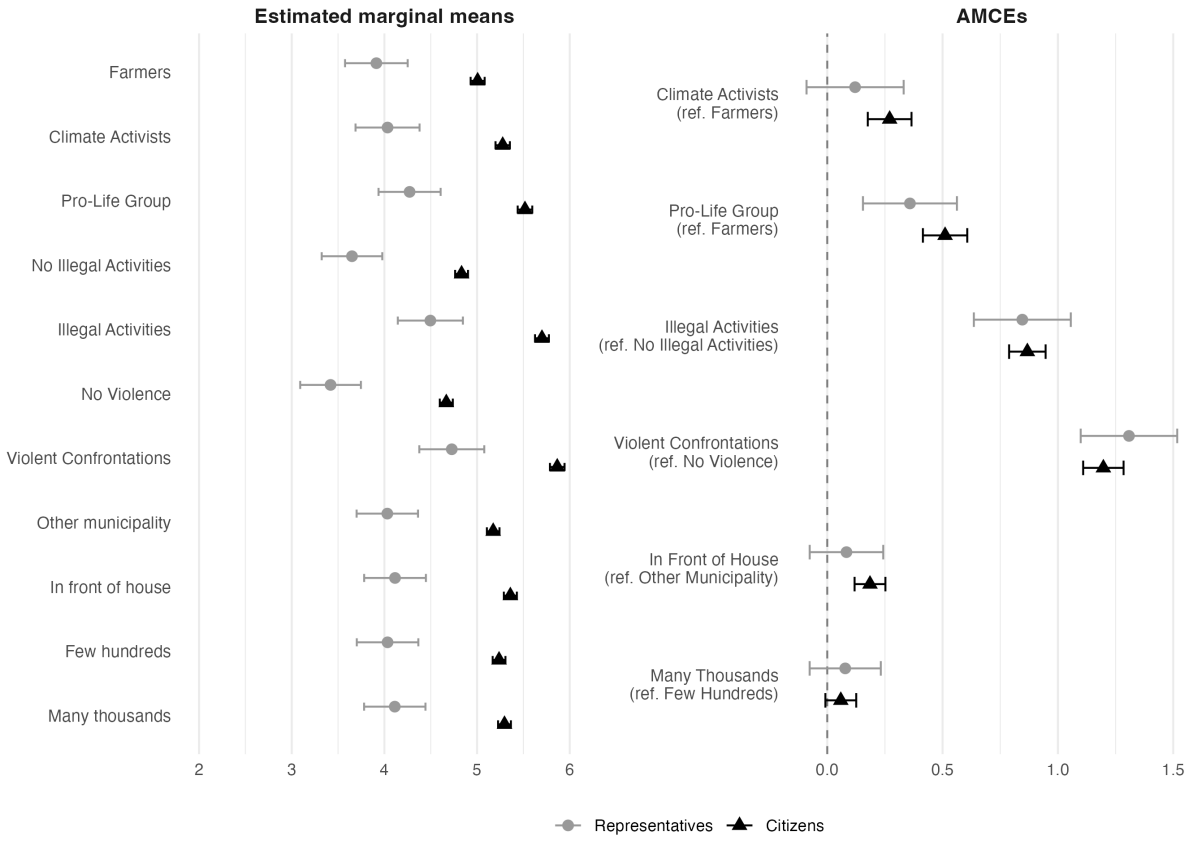
where Ban_{ict} is respondent i's support for banning the protest described in profile t in country c, where t indexes the profiles evaluated by each respondent. Rep_i is a dummy variable equal to 1 for representatives and 0 for citizens, and $Trait_{jict}$ is a dummy variable indicating the presence of the jth non-reference attribute level in profile t evaluated by respondent i in country c. The coefficients β_j capture the AMCEs among citizens (the reference category), while δ_j capture the difference in AMCEs between representatives and citizens for each attribute level. The main effect α captures baseline differences in support for banning between representatives and citizens when all attributes are at their reference levels. The coefficients γ_c denote country indicators, and λ_c capture country-by-representative-status interactions. J represents the total number of non-reference attribute levels across all five attributes.[9] Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Figure 1 presents estimated marginal mean (left panel) and average marginal component effects (right panel) from Equation 1.Averaged across all attribute levels and countries, citizens' support

[8]The model includes 47,638 profile observations from 1,073 politicians and 4,959 citizens across the five countries.

[9]Models ran separately by respondent type (citizens or representatives) yield identical results and are reported in the Online Appendix.

Figure 1: Support for Banning Street Protests among Representatives and Citizens



Note: Estimated marginal means (left panel) and average marginal component effects (right panel) of support for banning street protests (0–10 scale) by respondent type and attribute level, based on a linear regression model interacting all conjoint attributes and countries with respondent type. Horizontal lines show 95% confidence intervals. Black triangles represent citizens; grey circles represent politicians. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

for banning a protest exceeds that of representatives by 1.19 on the 0–10 scale ($p < .001$).[10] These results provide strong support for Hypothesis 1.[11] The gap between representatives and citizens persists after accounting for compositional differences between the two groups. Even highly educated and politically engaged citizens remain substantially more supportive of restricting protest than representatives.[12] Moreover, the gap is broadly similar across the ideological

[10]The marginal means weight each country equally. Weighting by observed sample frequencies yields a nearly identical gap of 1.25 points.

[11]A similar pattern emerges when comparing national representatives, regional representatives, and citizens, as shown in Figure A5 in the Appendix.

[12]Figures A8 and A9 in the Appendix present the full results.

spectrum.[13] Taken together, these findings suggest that representatives' greater tolerance toward contentious politics is not simply a consequence of compositional differences between the two groups. Rather, it is consistent with differences associated with political experience, institutional roles, or other features of political office.[14]

Behavioral violations emerge as the strongest determinants of support for banning protests among both representatives and citizens. Among citizens, violent confrontations increase support for banning by 1.22 points and illegal activities by 0.90 points. The corresponding effects among representatives are nearly identical: violence increases support by 1.33 points and illegal activity by 0.88 points. These findings provide support for Hypotheses 5 and 4.[15]. Considering the two behavioral attributes jointly, support for banning protests that are both legal and non-violent average at 4.23 among citizens and 3.00 among representatives on the 0–10 scale. When protests combine both illegal activity and violent confrontations, support for banning increases substantially, reaching 6.30 among citizens and 5.15 among representatives. While both citizens and representatives draw similar behavioral boundaries, these results also reveal that opposition to protest is not solely a reaction to behavior: even in the absence of illegal activity or violence, a nontrivial share of citizens and representatives still supports restricting protest rights.[16]

The effects of violent and illegal behavior could reflect either a response to violations of democratic norms or concerns about the threat posed by disruptive protest. Figure 1 provides greater support for the former interpretation. Other attributes that capture the potential disruptive

[13] See Figure A6 in the Appendix for marginal means by ideology group.

[14] A potential concern is that differences between representatives and citizens partly reflect survey mode, as representatives were primarily interviewed in person whereas citizens completed the survey online. Swiss regional representatives were interviewed both in person and online, allowing us to test for mode effects without confounding country and level of office. Figure A7 in the Appendix reports the full comparison and shows no mode effects: overall support for banning does not differ by interview mode, and the AMCEs are jointly indistinguishable across modes.

[15] Results are robust to excluding citizen respondents who completed the conjoint tasks in under 20 seconds, to estimating separate models for citizens by country, and to jackknife exclusion of politician countries (Figures A2 and A3 in the Appendix)

[16] Aggregating to the respondent level, 19.2% of citizens and 16.3% of representatives assign an average score of 7 or higher to the legal, non-violent protest profiles they evaluate. Because of the conjoint randomization, respondents evaluate between one and seven such profiles and we classify respondents based on their mean rating.

capacity of protests, such as their size and proximity to respondents' residences, have very limited effects.[17] Proximity increases support for banning by only 0.22 points among citizens, while protest size has no statistically significant effect. The corresponding effects among representatives are similarly small and statistically indistinguishable from zero. These results provide at best weak support for Hypothesis 2 and refute Hypothesis 3. Even more importantly, threat-related cues do not amplify reactions to behavioral violations. Neither the interaction between violent confrontations and proximity ($\hat{\beta} = -0.04$, $p = 0.511$) nor between violent confrontations and size ($\hat{\beta} = -0.003$, $p = 0.957$) achieves statistical significance.[18] These patterns suggest that intolerance is driven by judgments about whether protesters adhere to democratic norms of peaceful and lawful contestation rather than any the immediate threat posed by contentious mobilization.

Although behavior constitute the strongest determinants of political intolerance, protest group type also independently shapes support for restrictions. Averaged across respondents, citizens are most supportive of banning Pro-Life Groups, followed by Climate Activists and Farmers. Relative to Farmers, support for banning increases by 0.51 points for Pro-Life Groups and 0.27 points for Climate Activists (both $p < 0.001$). Among representatives, only Pro-Life Groups receive significantly greater support for restrictions than Farmers ($\hat{\beta} = 0.358$, $p = 0.001$).[19] These average effects, however, conceal substantial ideological heterogeneity. If respondents selectively extend civil liberties to ideological allies while withholding them from ideological opponents, aggregate differences across protest groups should mask opposing patterns across the ideological

[17] Because attributes are randomised independently, respondents occasionally saw combinations that may be less common, e.g., a protest of several thousand people taking place in front of the respondent's home in a sparsely populated municipality. We assess this by matching citizen respondents' postal codes to Eurostat's degree of urbanisation classification (European Union - GISCO 2024). Evaluations of the location–size combination do not differ across these contexts, nor do AMCEs more generally. Among rural respondents, a large protest raises support for banning by 0.25 points when it is planned in front of their home rather than in another municipality, against 0.26 points among urban respondents. Response dispersion on these profiles is likewise comparable across contexts (SD $= 3.49$ in rural areas against 3.41 in cities), giving no indication that rural respondents found the combination harder to evaluate.

[18] Full results are presented in Table A4 in the Appendix.

[19] The pattern is similar among regional and national representatives. See Figure A4 in the Appendix.

spectrum.

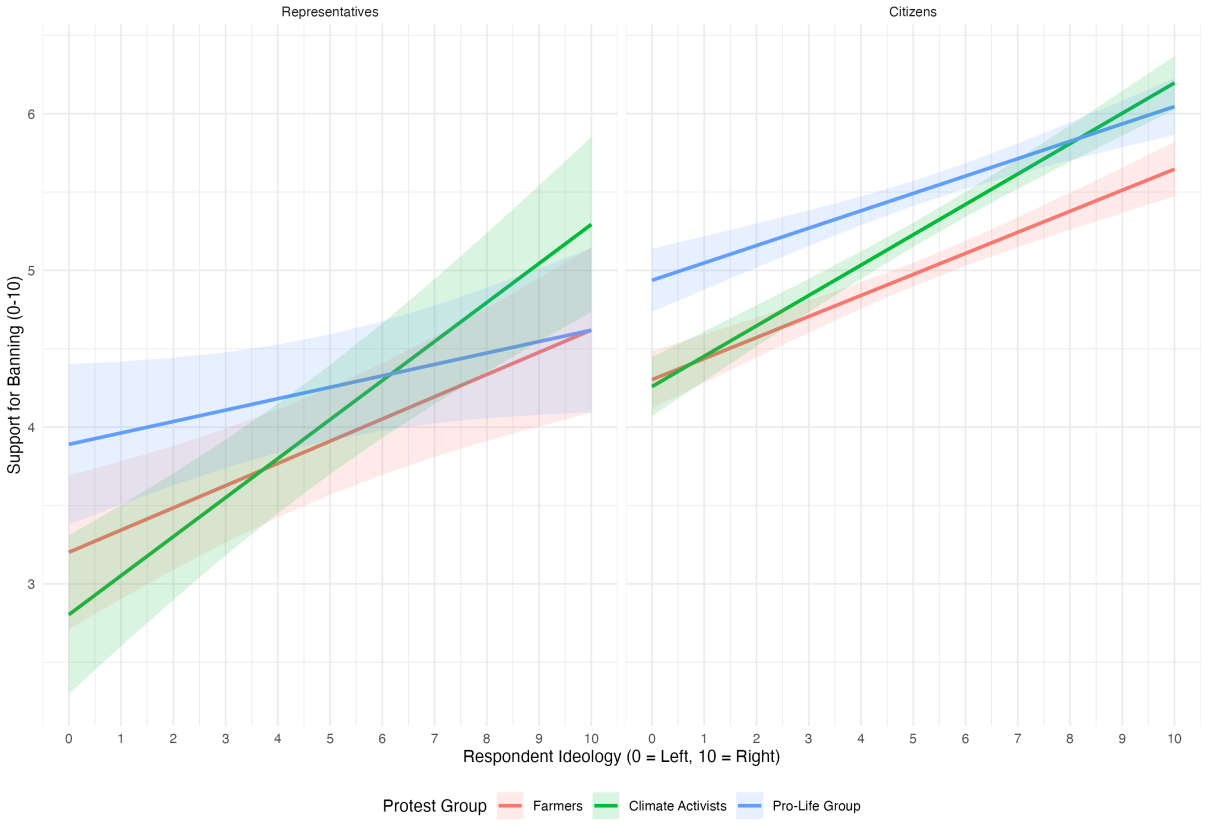
Figure 2 examines this possibility by interacting protest group identity with respondents' ideological self-placement.[20] The results reveal ideological in-group favoritism among both citizens and representatives. Respondents on the political left are substantially more willing to restrict Pro-Life Groups than Climate Activists, providing strong support for Hypothesis 6. Conversely, right-leaning representatives become increasingly supportive of restricting Climate Activists relative to Pro-Life Groups, consistent with Hypothesis 7. Among citizens, however, this asymmetry largely disappears at the ideological extreme. Rather than singling out Climate Activists, respondents on the far right express high levels of support for banning both groups. Overall, these findings suggest that support for protest rights is conditioned not only by whether protesters comply with democratic norms but also by whether they are ideological allies or opponents.

We further assess this interpretation using respondents' pre-conjoint evaluations of each protest group. Consistent with the ideological patterns in Figure 2, Figure **??**) shows that greater liking of the shown group is associated with significantly lower support for banning its protest ($b = -0.12$, $p < 0.001$).[21] This relationship does not differ significantly between representatives and citizens ($p = 0.77$), indicating that both groups are similarly influenced by their affective orientations toward protesters. Importantly, this relationship persists after holding constant the group's behavior and all other protest characteristics. Thus, although violence and illegality remain the primary determinants of support for restricting protest, respondents are systematically more willing to protect the civil liberties of groups they view favorably. Behavioral reciprocity

[20] We extend Equation 1 by interacting protest group identity with respondents' ideological self-placement on a 0–10 left–right scale.

[21] The model interacts respondents' liking of the group shown (0–10 scale) with respondent type and controls for respondents' mean liking across all seven groups rated. This isolates group-specific liking from general warmth towards groups.

Figure 2: Support for Banning Street Protests by Respondent Ideology and Protest Group

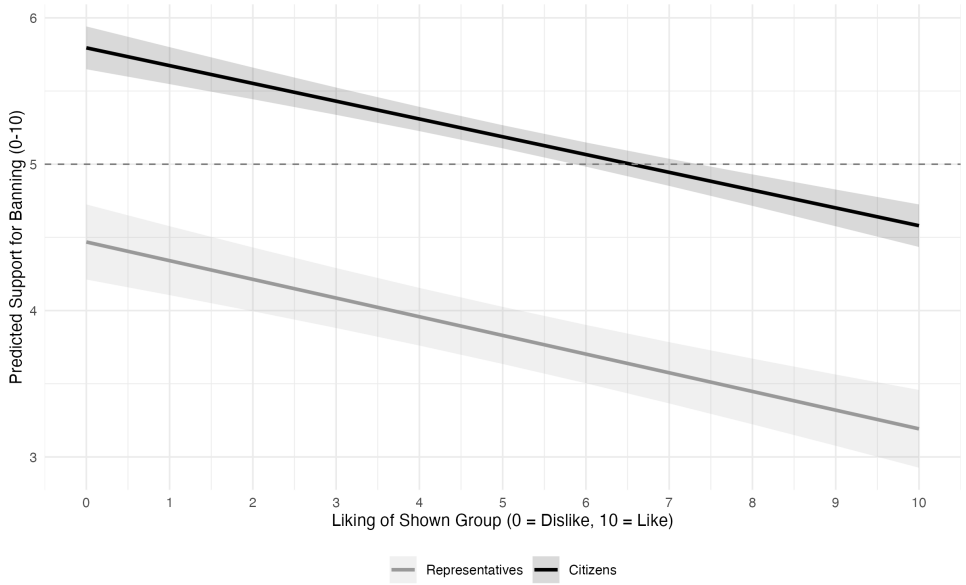


Note: Lines report predicted support for banning a protest group estimated from an extension of Equation 1 that interacts protest group type with respondents' ideological self-placement on a 0–10 left–right scale. The left panel displays results for representatives and the right panel for citizens. The outcome is measured on a 0–10 scale, with higher values indicating greater support for banning. Shaded areas denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

therefore constrains political intolerance but does not fully insulate judgments from affective or ideological considerations.

Taken together, these findings reveal that democratic tolerance is structured by two distinct principles. Behavioral violations of democratic norms constitute the primary basis on which both citizens and representatives withdraw support for civil liberties, consistent with democratic reciprocity. Yet reciprocity does not eliminate ideological bias. Even when protest behavior is held constant, respondents remain more willing to restrict the rights of ideological opponents than

Figure 3: Predicted Support for Banning Street Protests by Group Liking



Note: Estimated support for banning a street protest as a function of respondents' liking of the group shown (0–10 scale), estimated from a model interacting liking with respondent type and controlling for respondents' mean liking across all seven groups rated. Shaded areas denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

those of ideological allies. Representatives differ from citizens principally in their higher baseline tolerance toward protest rather than in the standards they apply to evaluate protest groups. The elite advantage in democratic tolerance is therefore real but limited: representatives are more willing to protect protest rights overall, yet they too apply these protections unevenly across political groups.

Conclusion

How does the political intolerance of elected officials compare to that of the citizens they represent, and what drives intolerance in each group? This paper addressed these questions through a conjoint experiment conducted among 4,965 citizens and 975 elected politicians across five European democracies (Belgium, Denmark, Germany, Portugal, and Switzerland). By varying behavioral, contextual, and identity-based attributes of protest groups, our design isolates

the mechanisms through which representatives and masses condition their support for restrictions on political expression.

Three key findings emerge. First, politicians exhibit systematically higher baseline tolerance than citizens. The gap of roughly 1.3 points on an 11-point scale is substantively large, persists among the most educated and politically engaged citizens, and holds across the ideological spectrum and across countries. This pattern is consistent with the classic elitist intuition that institutional experience cultivates tolerant orientations among politicians (McClosky 1964; Sullivan et al. 1982), though our design cannot fully differentiate between socialization, strategic self-presentation, and potential social desirability as competing mechanisms.[22] Second, behavioral transgressions (violent confrontations and illegal activity) are the dominant drivers of intolerance for both representatives and citizens, and produce effects of comparable magnitude across the two groups. Threat-based attributes such as proximity and group size have substantially weaker effects, and the null interaction between violence and proximity suggests that violence shapes intolerance through the violation of democratic norms of peaceful contestation rather than through realistic physical threat (Petersen et al. 2011). Third, both politicians and citizens selectively apply civil liberties along ideological lines, penalizing out-group protesters more than in-group ones. However, there is one exception: Far-right citizens support banning at elevated levels irrespective of group identity. This is an example of indiscriminate, rather than directional, intolerance.

These findings speak directly to the literature documenting the conditional nature of support for democratic norms. Recent scholarship has shown that mass publics tolerate undemocratic behavior when it advantages their own side, and that partisans systematically rationalize violations committed by co-partisans (Graham and Svolik 2020; Krishnarajan 2023). Our results extend these insights in two directions. They show, first, that partisan discounting of civil liberties

[22] We consider the social desirability bias to be unlikely given the observed ideological bias and the fact the results fully replicate among representatives who filled the survey online.

is not limited to citizens: elected politicians also evaluate protest rights through an ideological lens, and they do so more consistently than citizens, whose directional pattern dissolves into undifferentiated intolerance at the far right. Second, they show that behavioral norms nevertheless retain binding force. The symmetry with which representatives and masses respond to violence and illegality suggests that procedural considerations provide a guardrail.

The implications of these findings are accordingly mixed. The elite–mass tolerance gap indicates that representative institutions may insulate civil liberties from some of the more exclusionary impulses evident in mass opinion, echoing the protective function long attributed to politicians (Dahl 1961). Yet the persistence of ideological discrimination among politicians signals that this protection is contingent. There are two main limitations to our conclusions. The conjoint design measures stated preferences rather than observable behavior, and our sample is drawn from established Western European democracies. Extending this agenda will require broader geographic coverage and designs that link stated tolerance to elite decisions. Whether elected representatives remain, as has long been presumed, the principal custodians of civil liberties may depend less on their average permissiveness than on their willingness to extend that permissiveness to groups they find ideologically objectionable—a test that, on the evidence presented here, they only partially pass.

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These are the Appendices to the paper "Political Tolerance of Protest among Citizens and Representatives in Five Democracies"

Contents

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Section 2: Robustness Checks 5

Section 1: Data

Citizens Data

Data collection took place in 2025. Table A1 reports the fieldwork dates, median completion time, and number of respondents retained after data quality controls. Respondents were recruited through Dynata's online panel. The surveys were developed by the research teams and administered using the Qualtrics platform. Ethical approval was obtained prior to data collection from XXX (decision number XXX)[anonymised].

Table A1: Citizens Data: Fieldwork and Sample Characteristics by Country

Country	Fieldwork Period	Median Completion Time (minutes)	N^a
Belgium (Wallonia)	2025 May–2025 June	16.5	1,949
Denmark	2025 May–2025 June	16.3	1,976
Germany	2025 May–2025 June	14.3	2,018
Portugal	2025 Oct.–2025 Dec.	16.1	1,848
Switzerland	2025 May–2025 Aug.	15.8	2,324

[a]The total N exceeds the analytic N because only a randomly selected half of the citizen sample received the conjoint experiment.

Country samples were quota-based, with quotas designed to approximate the population distributions of age, gender, and education. Age and gender were crossed into 12 categories (six age categories by two gender categories). The Swiss sample oversampled respondents from the cantons of Fribourg and Bern to facilitate comparisons with politicians from the corresponding cantonal parliaments. Given the nature of the study, the sample is limited to respondents aged 18 and older with access to the internet. A proportional weight was created to adjust the sample distribution to match the population distribution by education, age, and gender. For Switzerland, the weight also adjusts the sample distribution across cantons to account for the oversampling of respondents in Fribourg and Bern. The conjoint estimates are based on the randomized sample, but we apply the weights to descriptive analyses.

Elected Representatives Data

Contact with members of parliament was initiated in each country through a formal email from the respective project PI describing the study, data-processing procedures, and participants' rights. A few weeks after the initial invitation, PIs or members of the research team followed up by telephone, personal email, in person in parliament, or through other contacts, including party elites, personal connections, and parliamentary staff. When elected representatives were reached, they typically either agreed to participate, declined (hard or soft refusal), or requested additional information. Politicians who agreed to participate were scheduled for an interview. Those requesting additional information received a brief description of the study. Hard refusals were not contacted again, whereas soft refusals (e.g., citing time constraints) were followed up four to six weeks later. Politicians who did not respond to the initial invitation received reminder emails and follow-up telephone calls. On average, approximately three contact attempts were required to secure participation. In some countries, researchers also recruited representatives directly in parliament on plenary sitting days, conducting interviews ad hoc or scheduling them for a later date.

Interviews were scheduled at times convenient for the participating representatives. All interviews were conducted in the presence of a researcher, either in person at the parliament or, occasionally, at another location chosen by the politician, or online via Zoom or Microsoft Teams. Staff members were almost never present during the interviews. Surveys were administered on a tablet or laptop provided by the research team. Similarly to the citizen data, ethical approval was obtained prior to data collection from XXX (decision number XXX)[anonymised].

Elected representatives data collection took place between 2025 and 2026. Table A2 reports the fieldwork period, population, response rate and interview mode for each country. Response rates ranged from 18% in Germany to 43% in Belgium, with an average of 31% across countries. Most interviews were conducted in person.

Table A2: Representatives Data: Fieldwork and Sample Characteristics by Country

Country	Fieldwork Period	Population	Response Rate	Interview Mode
Belgium (Wallonia)	May 2025–Feb. 2026	211 Representatives 63 Federal French-speaking MPs 75 Walloon MPs 73 Brussels French-speaking MPs 25 party leaders and ministers	91 (43%)	In person: 70% Online: 30%
Denmark	May 2025–Jan. 2026	179 Members of the national parliament	37 (21%)	In person: 79% Online: 21%
Germany	March 2025–March 2026	633 Members of the national parliament	116 (18%)	In person: 6% Online: 94%
Portugal	July 2025–Nov. 2025	230 Members of the national parliament	88 (38%)	In person: 100%
Switzerland	March 2025–Oct. 2025	646 Representatives 246 Federal Assembly MPs 130 Grand Council of Valais MPs 160 Grand Council of Bern MPs 110 Grand Council of Fribourg MPs	250 (39%)	In person: 61% Online: 39%

Table A3: Representativeness of the Representatives Sample

Panel A: Demographic Characteristics and Political Experience

		Total N	Female	Age in years (SD)	Political experience (SD)
Belgium (Wallonia)	Sample	91	36 (39.6%)	50.8 (10.4)	8.0 (6.8)
	Population	211	92 (43.6%)	49.8 (10.3)	7.8 (6.5)
Denmark	Sample	37	12 (32.4%)	48.5 (11.5)	10.0 (7.7)
	Population	179	80 (44.7%)	50.8 (10.7)	11.4 (6.7)
Germany	Sample	116	43 (37.1%)	46.2 (11.1)	4.68 (6.0)
	Population	633	205 (32.6%)	47.1 (11.1)	6.3 (7.2)
Portugal	Sample	88	28 (31.82%)	47.5 (11.5)	5.42 (9.0)
	Population	230	83 (36.09%)	49.5 (10.7)	5.59 (7.8)
Switzerland	Sample	250	105 (42.0%)	48.1 (12.0)	6.0 (6.0)
	Population	646	237 (36.7%)	50.9 (10.7)	8.9 (7.7)

Panel B: Ideological Composition

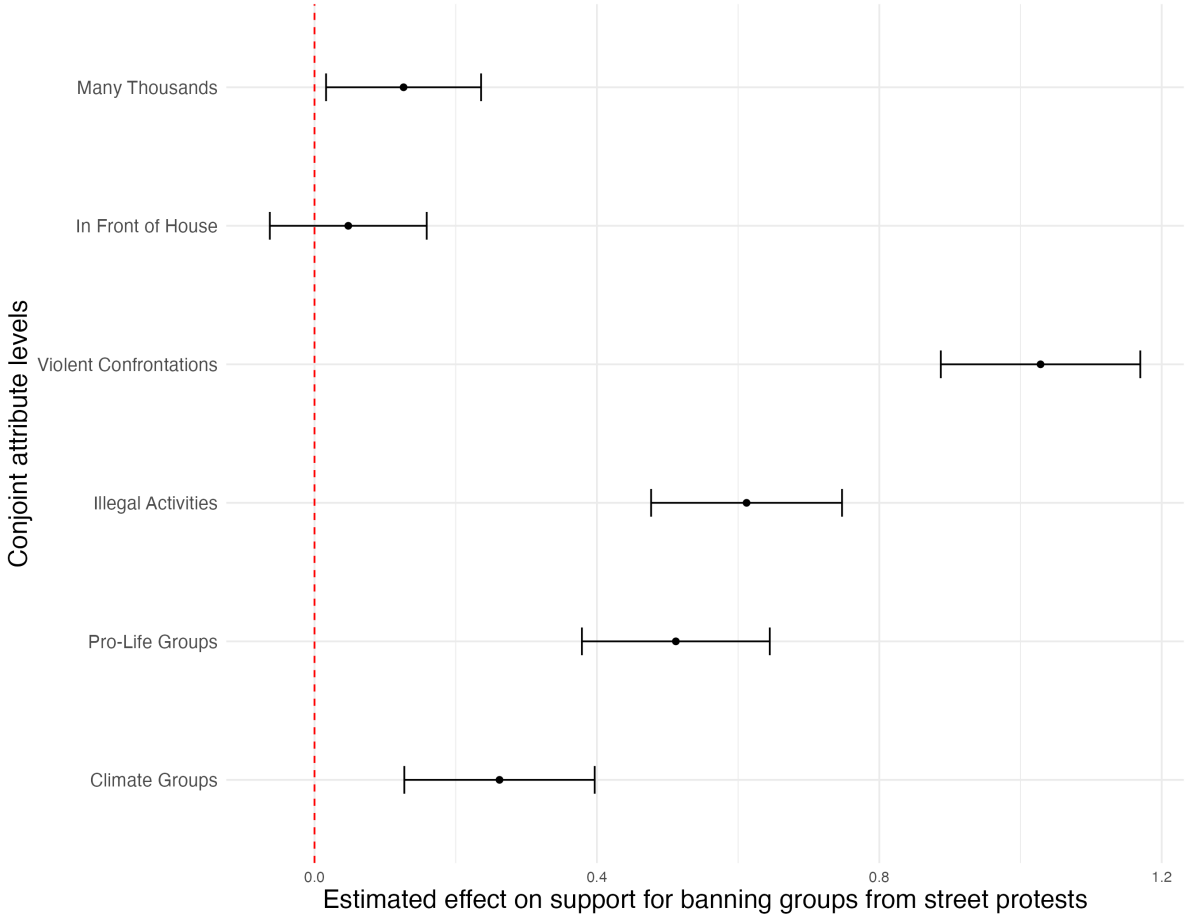
		Total N	Left (CHES 0–3)	Centre (CHES 4–6)	Right (CHES 7–10)	Other
Belgium (Wallonia)	Sample	91	39 (42.8%)	25 (27.5%)	27 (29.7%)	0 (0%)
	Population	211	100 (47.4%)	46 (21.8%)	65 (30.8%)	0 (0%)
Denmark	Sample	37	8 (21.6%)	14 (37.8%)	12 (32.4%)	3 (8.1%)
	Population	179	31 (17.3%)	70 (39.1%)	68 (38.0%)	10 (5.6%)
Germany	Sample	116	63 (54.3%)	24 (20.7%)	29 (25.0%)	0 (0%)
	Population	633	271 (42.8%)	165 (26.1%)	195 (30.8%)	2 (0.3%)
Portugal	Sample	88	4 (4.54%)	74 (84.09%)	9 (10.23%)	1 (1.14%)
	Population	230	11 (4.78%)	156 (67.83%)	62 (26.96%)	1 (0.43%)
Switzerland	Sample	250	108 (43.2%)	73 (29.2%)	68 (27.2%)	1 (0.4%)
	Population	646	195 (30.2%)	173 (26.8%)	276 (42.7%)	2 (0.3%)

To assess the representativeness of our sample, we compare the characteristics of participating representatives with those of the population of representatives in terms of gender, age, political experience, and ideology. To analyze ideological representation, we use parties' general left–right scores from the 2024 Chapel Hill Expert Survey (Rovny et al. 2025). We classify parties with scores from 0 to 3.99 as left-wing, 4.00 to 6.99 as center, and 7.00 to 10 as right-wing.

As shown in Table A3, the participating representatives broadly resemble the respective populations. Differences in average age and political experience are generally modest. The gender and ideological composition of the samples is broadly comparable to that of the underlying populations, although some deviations are evident. For example, the German sample contains larger share of left-leaning representatives, while the Swiss sample contains fewer right-leaning representatives than the population. Overall, however, the comparisons suggest that the samples provide a reasonable approximation of the populations of elected representatives in the five settings.

Section 2: Robustness Checks

Figure A1: The Effect of Protest Characteristics on Support for the Ban (Pooled model)



Note: Coefficient estimates from a linear regression model where the outcome variable is support for banning a group from protesting. Dots represent the estimated average marginal component effect (AMCE) of each attribute, and horizontal lines represent 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent and task levels. The red dashed line indicates zero. The baseline categories for the attributes are: a protest by Farmers group, no illegal activities, no violent confrontations, held in another municipality, and involving a few hundreds people.

Table A4: Effect of Group Attributes on Support for Banning the Protest

Model:	(1)
Variables	
Illegal Activities (ref. No Illegal Activities)	0.868***
	(0.038)
Violent Confrontations (ref. No Violence)	1.232***
	(0.061)
In Front of House (ref. Other Municipality)	0.184***
	(0.045)
Many Thousands (ref. Few Hundreds)	0.070
	(0.044)
Violent Confrontations × In Front of House	-0.042
	(0.063)
Violent Confrontations × Many Thousands	-0.003
	(0.063)
Climate Activists (ref. Farmers)	0.247***
	(0.039)
Pro-Life Group (ref. Farmers)	0.487***
	(0.039)
Denmark	-0.046
	(0.098)
Germany	0.336***
	(0.094)
Portugal	0.286***
	(0.095)
Switzerland	0.080
	(0.088)
Constant	3.546***
	(0.082)
Fit statistics	
Observations	47,638
R^2	0.0514

Clustered (resp_id) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Note: OLS estimates with standard errors clustered at the respondent level. The dependent variable is support for banning the protest (0–10 scale). Interaction terms test whether the effects of protest proximity and size differ between violent and nonviolent groups.

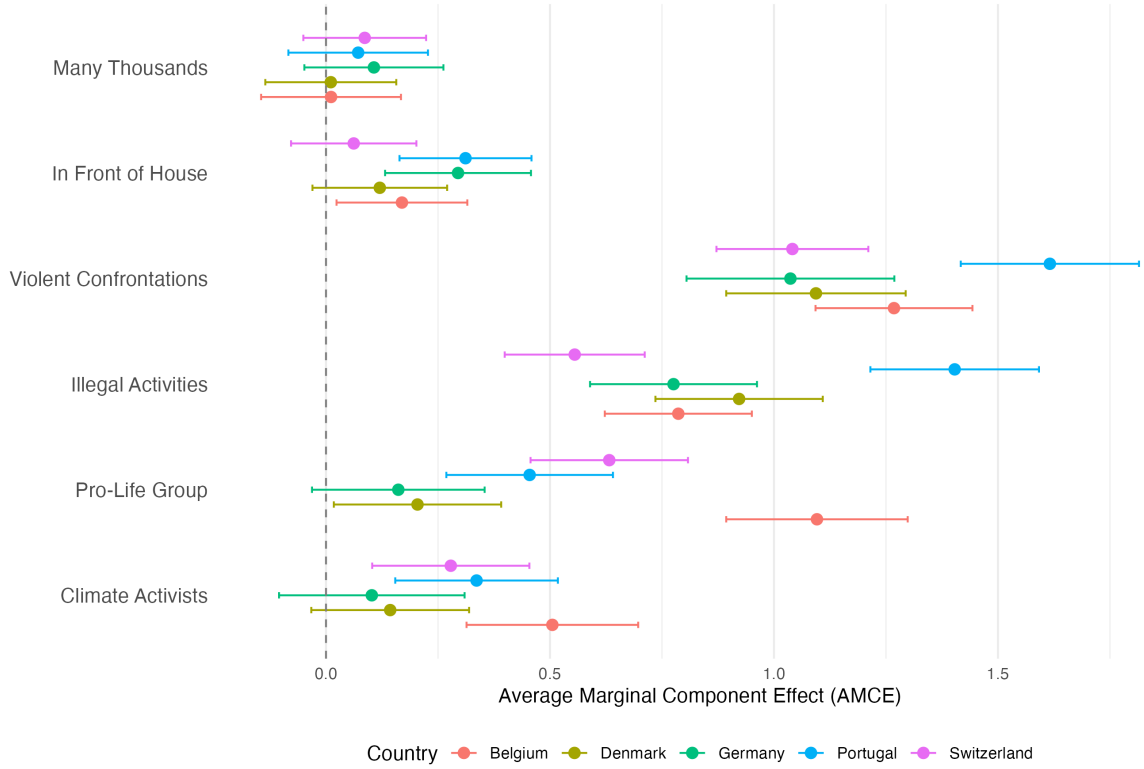
Table A5: Effect of Group Attributes on Support for Banning the Protest for Citizens and Politicians

Model:	(1)
Variables	
Climate Activists (ref. Farmers)	0.121
	(0.095)
Pro-Life Group (ref. Farmers)	0.358***
	(0.092)
Illegal Activities (ref. No Illegal Activities)	0.846***
	(0.107)
Violent Confrontations (ref. No Violence)	1.327***
	(0.116)
In Front of House (ref. Other Municipality)	0.100
	(0.087)
Many Thousands (ref. Few Hundreds)	0.087
	(0.084)
Citizens (ref. Politicians)	1.315***
	(0.148)
Denmark	-0.118
	(0.097)
Germany	0.244***
	(0.094)
Portugal	0.279***
	(0.094)
Switzerland	0.538***
	(0.090)
Climate Activists × Citizens	0.149
	(0.104)
Pro-Life Group × Citizens	0.152
	(0.102)
Illegal Activities × Citizens	0.022
	(0.115)
Violent Confrontations × Citizens	-0.103
	(0.116)
In Front of House × Citizens	0.108
	(0.088)
Many Thousands × Citizens	-0.024
	(0.086)
Violent Confrontations × In Front of House	-0.045
	(0.062)
Violent Confrontations × Many Thousands	-0.009
	(0.062)
Constant	2.336***
	(0.151)
Fit statistics	
Observations	47,638
R^2	0.0705

Clustered (resp_id) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Note: OLS estimates with standard errors clustered at the respondent level. The dependent variable is support for banning the protest (0–10 scale). Main effects capture AMCEs for politicians (the reference category). Interaction terms with Citizens capture differences in AMCEs between citizens and politicians. The final two rows test whether the effects of protest proximity and size are amplified when the protest involves violent confrontations; neither interaction is statistically significant, indicating that these attributes operate additively.

Figure A2: Support for Banning Street Protests, by Country (Citizens)

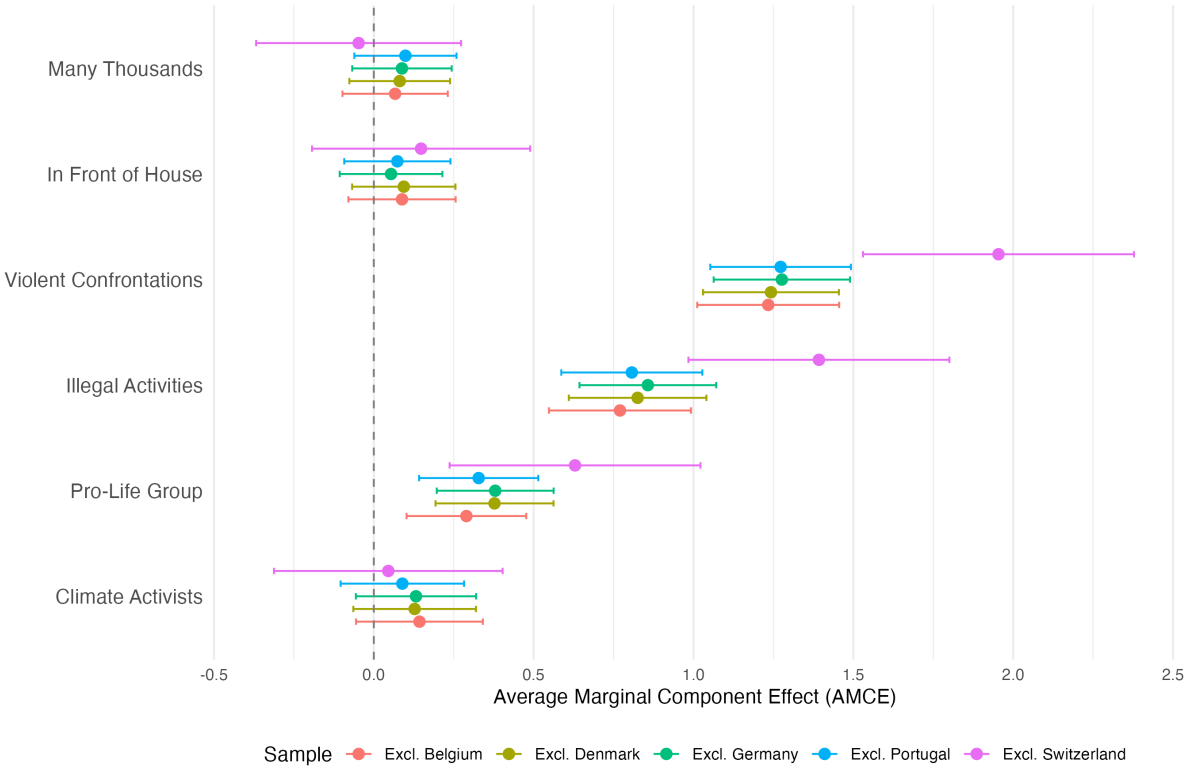


Note: Average marginal component effects (AMCEs) of each attribute on support for banning street protests (0–10 scale), estimated separately for citizens in each country. Dots represent the estimated AMCE of each attribute level relative to its reference category, and horizontal lines show 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. The dashed line indicates zero effect. Reference categories are: Farmers (group identity), no illegal activities, no violent confrontations, protest held in another municipality, and few hundreds of participants.

References

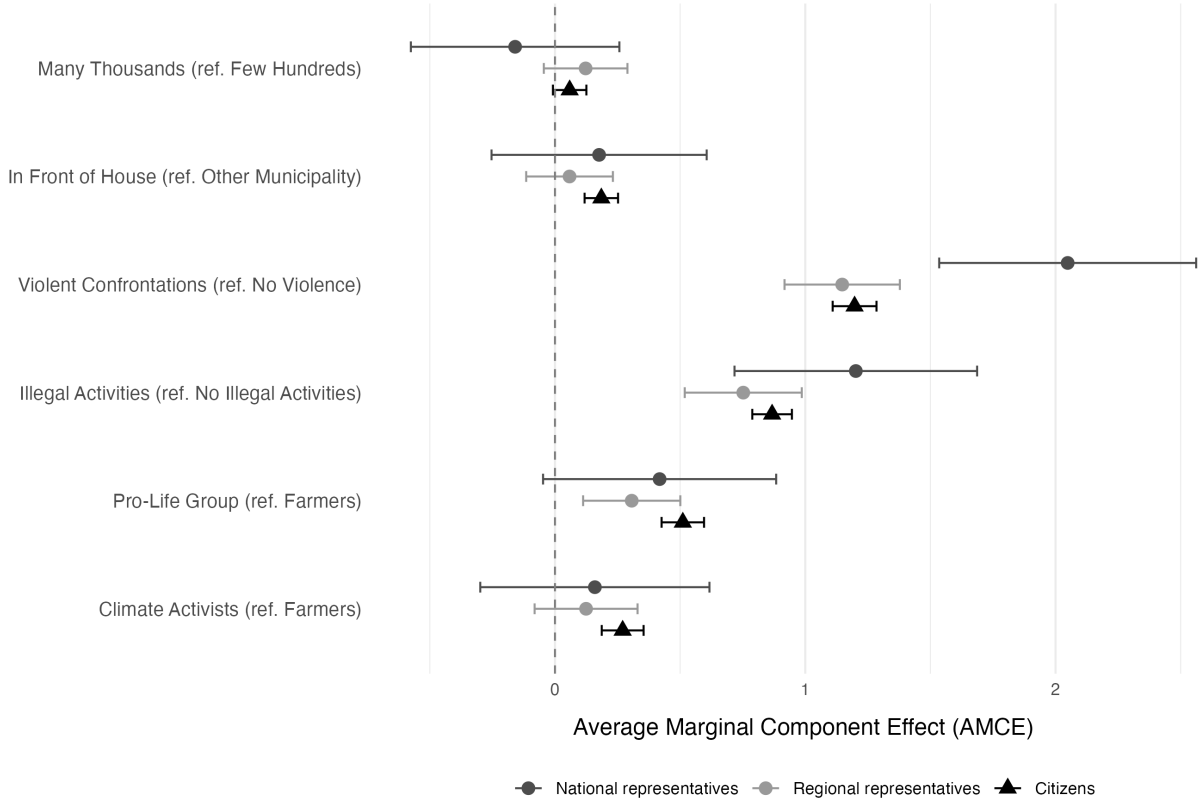
Rovny, Jan, Jonathan Polk, Ryan Bakker, Liesbet Hooghe, Seth Jolly, Gary Marks, Marco Steenbergen, and Milada Anna Vachudova. 2025. "The 2024 Chapel Hill Expert Survey on political party positioning in Europe: Twenty-five years of party positional data." *Electoral Studies* 97:102981. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.electstud.2025.102981.

Figure A3: Support for Banning Street Protests, Jackknife by Politician Country



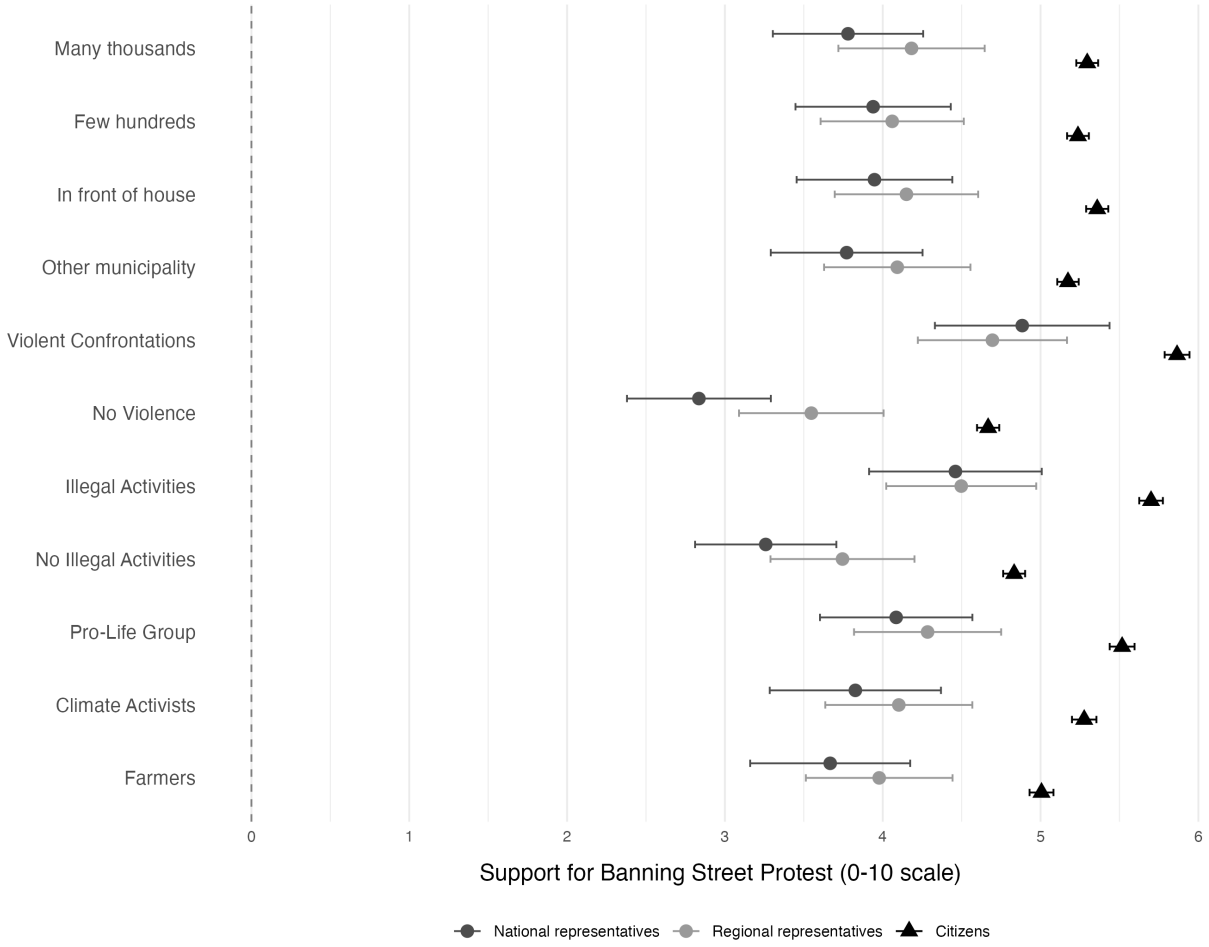
Note: Average marginal component effects (AMCEs) of each attribute on support for banning street protests (0–10 scale), estimated from pooled politician samples sequentially excluding each country. Dots represent the estimated AMCE of each attribute level relative to its reference category, and horizontal lines show 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. The dashed line indicates zero effect. Reference categories are: Farmers (group identity), no illegal activities, no violent confrontations, protest held in another municipality, and few hundreds of participants.

Figure A4: Average Marginal Component Effects on Support for Banning Street Protests among Citizens, Regional Representatives, and National Representatives



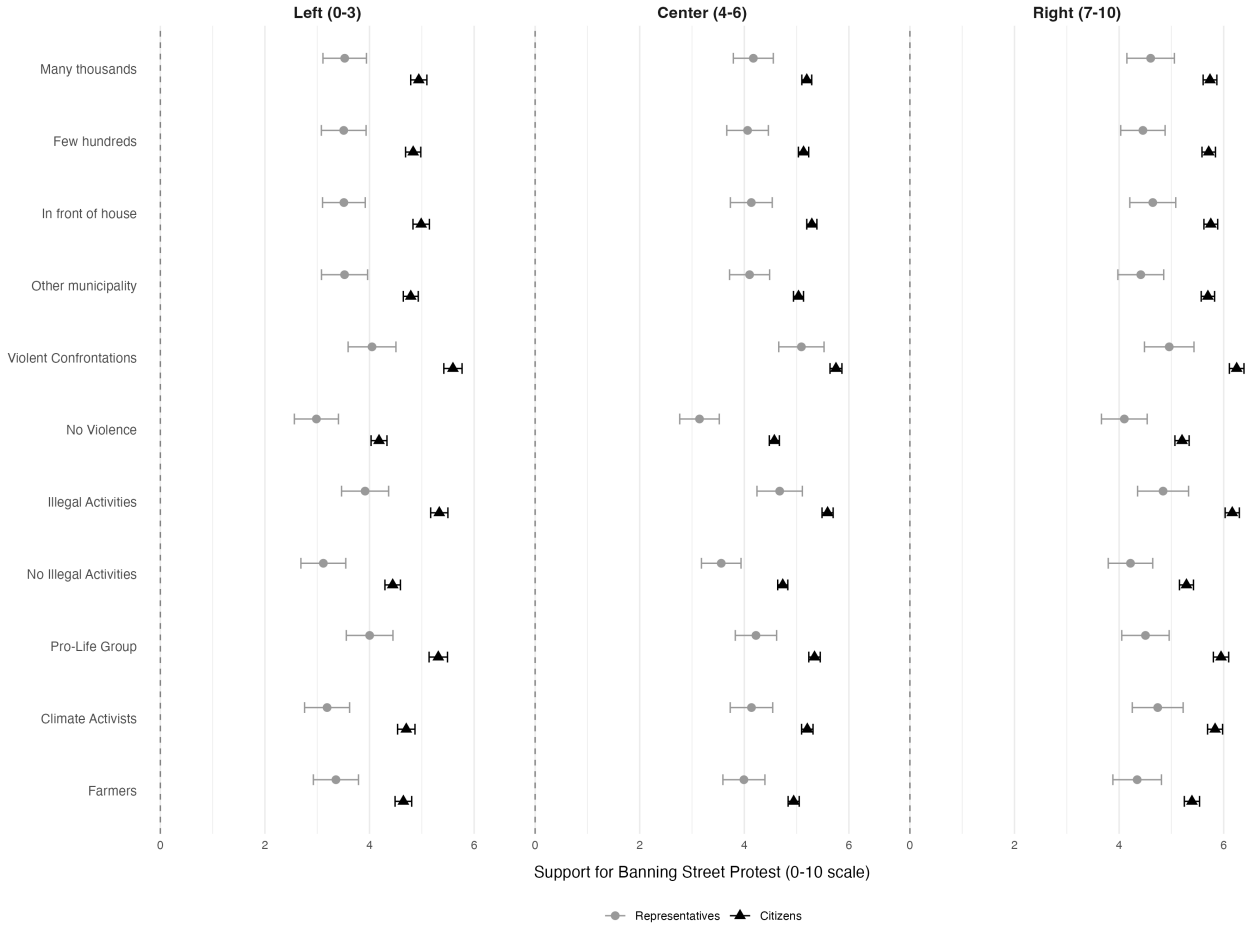
Note: Average marginal component effects (AMCEs) of each attribute on support for banning street protests (0–10 scale), estimated from a model interacting each conjoint attribute with an indicator for respondent type (citizens, regional representatives, national representatives), with country interactions. Dots represent the estimated AMCE of each attribute level relative to its reference category, and horizontal lines show 95% confidence intervals. Black triangles represent citizens, light grey circles represent regional representatives, and dark grey circles represent national representatives. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. Reference categories are: Farmers (group identity), no illegal activities, no violent confrontations, protest held in another municipality, and few hundreds of participants.

Figure A5: Support for Banning Street Protests among Citizens, Regional Representatives, and National Representatives



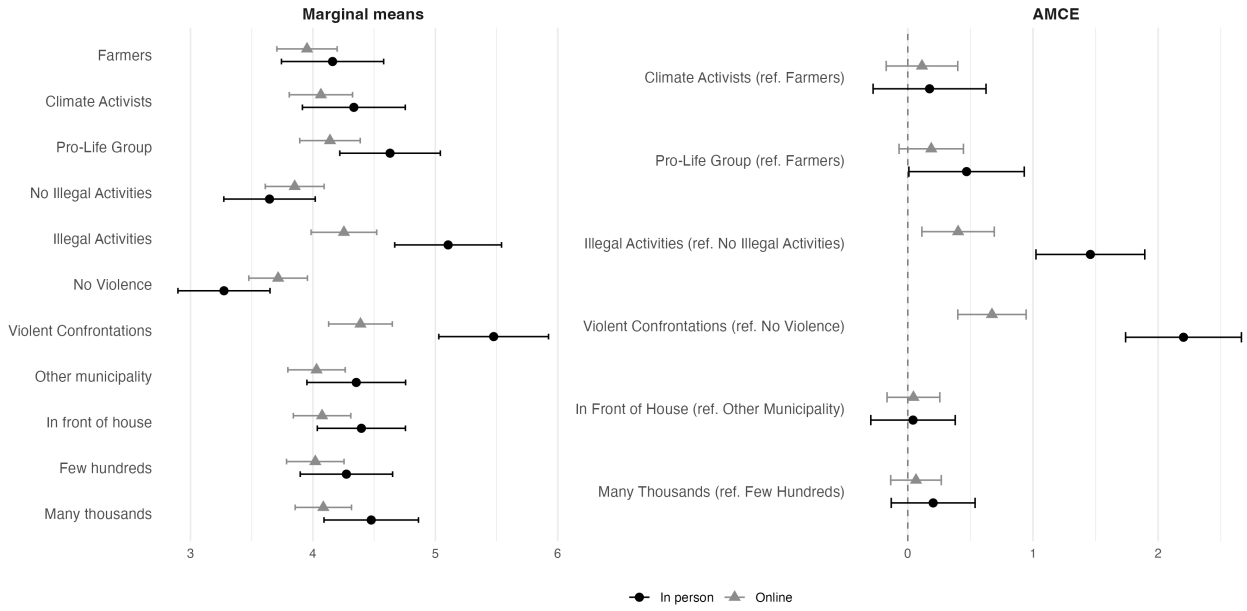
Note: Predicted marginal means of support for banning street protests (0–10 scale) for each attribute level, estimated from a model interacting each conjoint attribute with an indicator for respondent type (citizens, regional representatives, national representatives), with country fixed effects. Dots indicate the predicted marginal mean support for each attribute level, averaged over the distribution of all other attributes and country fixed effects, with horizontal lines showing 95% confidence intervals. Black triangles represent citizens, light grey circles represent regional representatives, and dark grey circles represent national representatives. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Figure A6: Support for Banning Street Protests by Ideology for Politicians and Citizens



Note: Predicted marginal means of support for banning street protests for politicians and citizens across all attribute levels, estimated from a fully interacted model including three-way interactions between conjoint attributes, elite status, and ideology group, with country interactions. Respondents are classified as left-leaning (ideology ≤ 3), centrist (ideology 4–6), or right-leaning (ideology ≥ 7) based on self-placement on a 0–10 left–right scale. Dots indicate the predicted marginal mean support (0–10 scale) for each attribute level, averaged over the distribution of all other attributes and countries, with horizontal lines showing 95% confidence intervals. Grey dots represent politicians and black triangles represent citizens. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Figure A7: Support for Banning Street Protests by Interview Mode, Swiss Regional Representatives



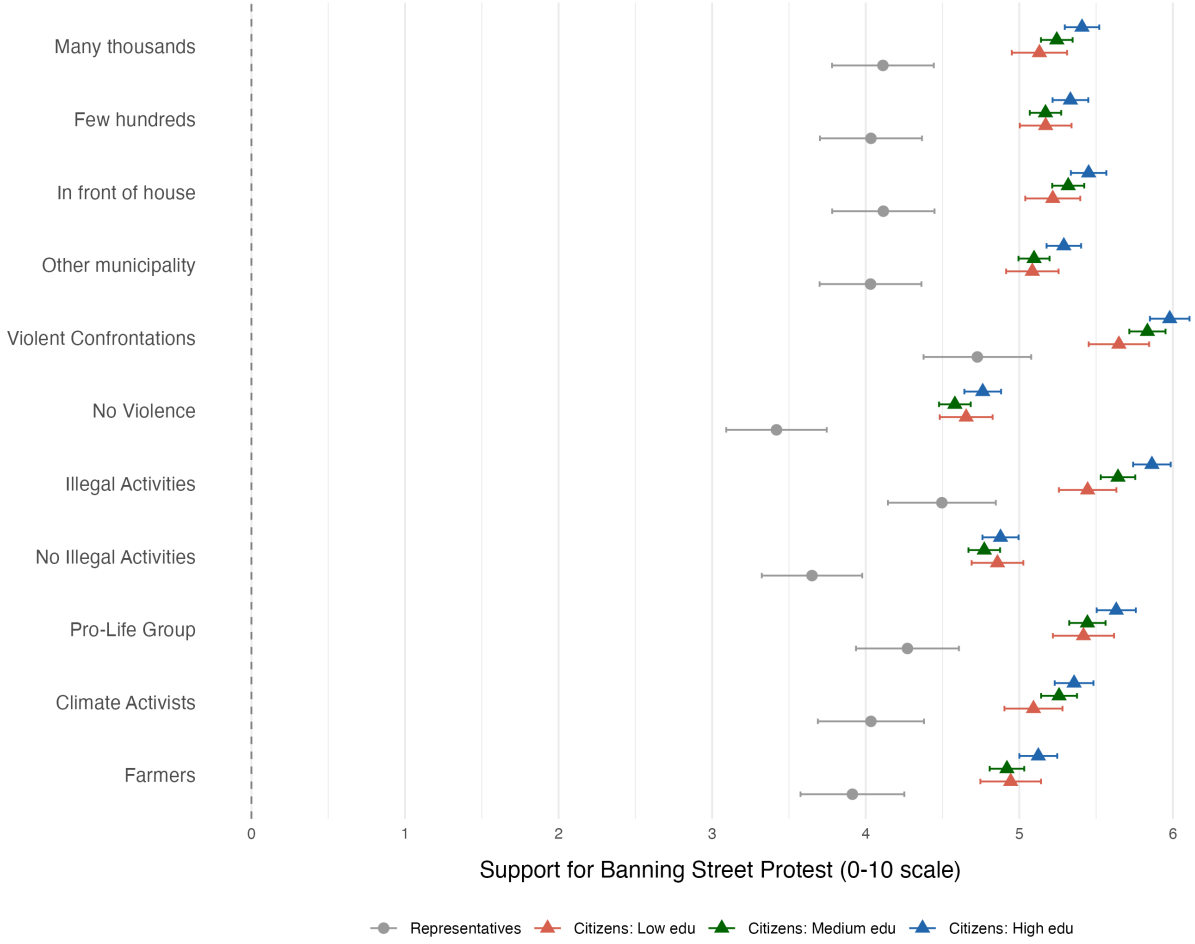
Note: Predicted marginal means (left panel) and average marginal component effects (right panel) of support for banning street protests, estimated from a fully interacted model including interactions between all conjoint attributes and interview mode. The sample is restricted to Swiss regional representatives ($n = 95$ interviewed in person, $n = 693$ online), which holds country and level of office constant and thereby isolates interview mode. Dots indicate the predicted marginal mean support (0–10 scale) or the estimated effect relative to the reference level, in each case averaged over the distribution of all other attributes, with horizontal lines showing 95% confidence intervals. Black circles represent representatives interviewed in person and grey triangles those interviewed online. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Table A6: Elite–Mass Gap in Support for Banning Street Protests by Ideology Group

		Respondent Ideology		
Contrast		Left (0–3)	Center (4–6)	Right (7–10)
Citizens – Regional representatives	$\hat{\delta}$	1.54***	1.25***	1.40***
	SE	(0.18)	(0.17)	(0.19)
Citizens – National representatives	$\hat{\delta}$	1.49***	1.26***	1.63***
	SE	(0.36)	(0.26)	(0.27)
Regional representatives – National representatives	$\hat{\delta}$	−0.05	0.00	0.23
	SE	(0.39)	(0.30)	(0.32)
N (Citizens)			31,732	
N (Regional representatives)			6,342	
N (National representatives)			2,042	

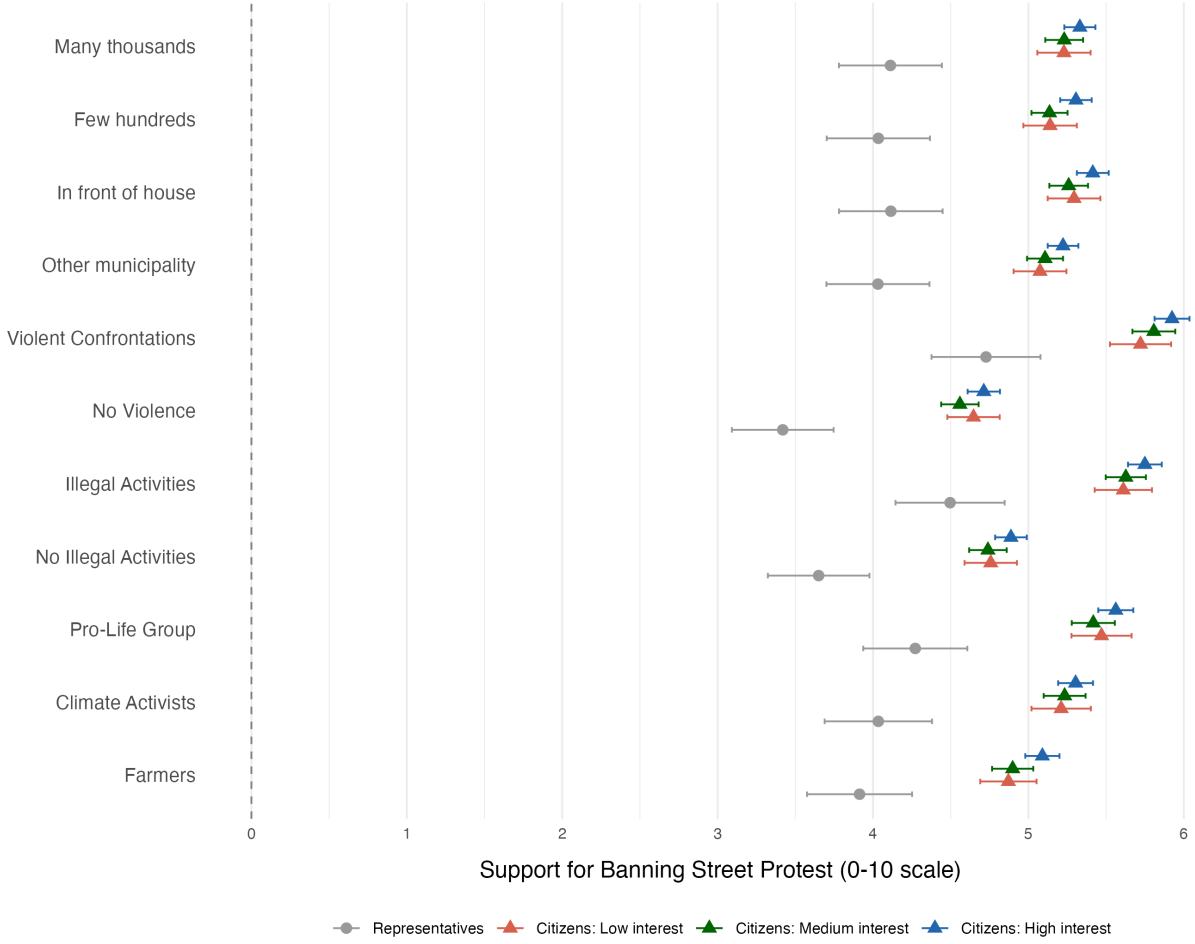
Note: Pairwise differences in predicted support for banning street protests (0–10 scale) between respondent groups within each ideology category, estimated from a fully interacted model including all conjoint attributes $\times$ elite status $\times$ ideology group, with country interactions. Standard errors (in parentheses) are clustered at the respondent level. The magnitude of the elite–mass gap does not vary significantly across ideology groups (Wald test: $F = 1.36$, $p = 0.115$). *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$.

Figure A8: Support for Banning Street Protests: Politicians and Citizens by Education Level



Note: Predicted marginal means of support for banning street protests for politicians and citizens grouped by education level, estimated from a single model with group interactions and country interactions. Dots indicate the predicted marginal mean support (0–10 scale) for each attribute level, averaged over the distribution of all other attributes and countries, with horizontal lines showing 95% confidence intervals. Grey dots represent politicians, coloured triangles represent citizen education groups. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Figure A9: Support for Banning Street Protests, Politicians and Citizens by Political Interest



Note: Predicted marginal means of support for banning street protests for politicians and citizens grouped by level of political interest, estimated from a single model with group interactions and country interactions. Dots indicate the predicted marginal mean support (0–10 scale) for each attribute level, averaged over the distribution of all other attributes and countries, with horizontal lines showing 95% confidence intervals. Grey dots represent politicians, coloured triangles represent citizen political interest groups. Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.